

You are *not* Alone



The other side of life

When you look in a mirror, you probably see just one living thing—*yourself*. But what you may not realize is that you are a **WALKING ECOSYSTEM** and that you *share your body* with millions of other organisms. Some are good, some are bad, and most are not nice to think about. Here's a guided tour of your fellow travelers.

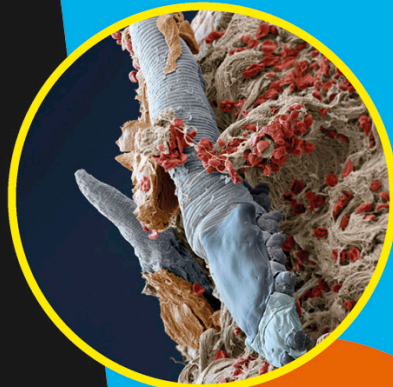
Hair

Head lice are tiny, wingless insects that suck blood from your scalp and stick their eggs to your hair. They cause itchy bumps on your skin but are not dangerous. They can spread rapidly from person to person and are not fussy about whether your hair is clean or dirty.



Eyelashes

These strumpy-legged little mites are around $\frac{1}{100}$ in (0.3 mm) long and live head-down in your eyelash follicles. They spend their time eating skin cells and breeding, although they may emerge at night for a wander around your face.



Gut

Adult humans carry around $\frac{3}{4}$ lb (1.5 kg) of bacteria in their guts. Most of these play a key part in digesting food and turning it into vital nutrients. But sometimes they can be overwhelmed by an invasion of bad bacteria and that's when you get an upset stomach.



 **FRIENDLY TRAVELERS**

 **UNWANTED VISITORS**

Mouth

Your mouth is full of bacteria. They coat the surface of your teeth, gums, and lining of your mouth and share your food. Around 25,000 different species live there, with 1,000 of these on your teeth where they form a yellow furry film called plaque. If left to harden, plaque makes holes in your teeth.

